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City the previous year, Ancelotti placed his faith in youngsters Rodrygo, Vinícius Jr, and new signing Jude Bellingham, a gamble that paid off in the club's run to UCL glory.

Drama from the get-go

Real Madrid and defending champion Manchester City were the only teams to complete the group stage with perfect records of six wins in six.

Erik ten Hag's Manchester United provided the biggest shock of the stage by failing to qualify from a group that included Bayern Munich, FC Copenhagen and Galatasaray, setting a record for the most goals

conceded (15) by a Premier League side in a UCL group stage.

Adding to their woes, United managed only one win and became the first English team to finish bottom of a Champions League group twice, having previously done so in 2005/06.

Arsenal made the most of its return to the Champions League after seven years, topping its group by netting 16 times in six games. Europa League specialist Sevilla failed to win a single group stage game, ending its season without an entry into the second-tier competition of European club football.

Leap of faith: A perfect header by Dani Carvajal (third from right) in the second half, assisted by a precise corner kick from Toni Kroos, broke the deadlock. AFP

FC Barcelona made it past the group stage for the first time since Lionel Messi's departure in 2021. However, Xavi's men showed signs of inconsistency with losses against Shakhtar Donetsk and Royal Antwerp F.C. in the group stage.

Runner-up Borussia Dortmund emerged victorious from the 'group of death' that included Paris Saint-Germain, AC Milan, and Newcastle United.

Eddie Howe's Newcastle United had a memorable start to its first Champions League campaign in 20 years with an emphatic 4-1 victory against Paris Saint-Germain at St James' Park.

But three losses and two draws in the remaining games left it finishing last, with AC Milan dropping to the Europa League.



This victory marked coach Carlo Ancelotti's fifth UCL title as a manager and his third in two spells with Los Blancos.